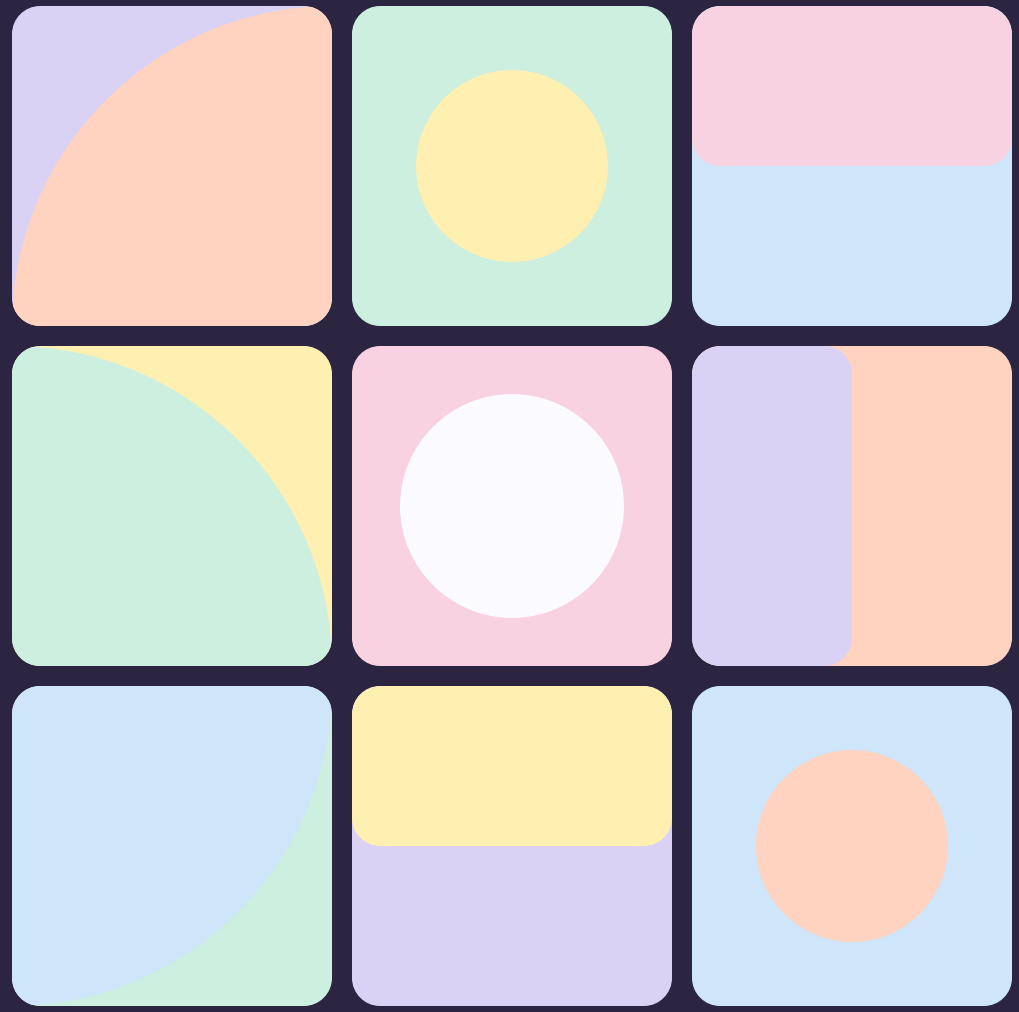
PRODUCT STRATEGY CASE STUDY

Bringing back the weekday lunch

A strategy to lift order frequency on Zomato, worked from diagnosis to rollout.

An independent product sense exercise. Not affiliated with Zomato. All figures are illustrative assumptions used to reason through the problem.



01 · THE BRIEF

Growth is slowing. Where exactly?

Before solving, split the headline number into the levers that make it up, then ask where the drop is coming from.

Total orders = Active users × Orders per active user

Clarifying questions asked

- Is the slowdown from fewer active users, or fewer orders per user?
- Is frequency dropping within segments, or only because the user mix changed?
- Which markets: metros, tier 2, or both?

What the data says (assumed)

- Active users are still growing
- Orders per user is falling, and it is falling within segments
- The drop is concentrated in metro cities

So the broken lever is

Frequency

Acquisition is working. Existing users are ordering less often.

01 · DIAGNOSIS

A falling average can be good news or bad news

Overall frequency is a weighted average of segments. Two scenarios show the same drop for opposite reasons.

STARTING POINT

SEGMENT	USERS	ORDERS / USER	ORDERS
Heavy	200	10	2,000
Light	800	2.5	2,000
Total	**1,000**	**4.0**	**4,000**

SCENARIO A · MIX SHIFT

500 new light users join. Nobody changes behavior.

Frequency 4.0 → 3.5
Total orders 4,000 → 5,250

Healthy growth. New users dilute the average. The job is turning them into regulars.

SCENARIO B · REAL DECLINE

Same users. Light users drop from 2.5 to 1.5 orders a month.

Frequency 4.0 → 3.2
Total orders 4,000 → 3,200

Existing users are ordering less. This is the real problem, and the one this case solves.

Always check segments before concluding. Only segment level data tells you which story is true.

02 · GOAL

One goal, with a number and guardrails

Raise orders per monthly transacting user from 3.2 to 3.8 in six months in metro cities, without lowering order value or adding notification fatigue.

Definition

Order frequency = completed orders in a month ÷ users who placed at least one order that month.

Cancelled and refunded orders excluded. Monthly window matches the natural food delivery cycle.

Why this goal, not others

- **More users:** already growing, not the problem
- **Higher order value:** does not fix ordering less often
- **Same restaurant repeats:** too narrow

Guardrails

- Average order value falls no more than 5%
- Notification opt out rate stays flat
- Cancellation rate stays flat

03 · SEGMENTS

Diagnose with behavior, solve with occasion

A strong segment combines two or three lenses: where the drop is, who they are, and why they order.

BEHAVIOR

How often they order. Heavy, medium, light.

LIFECYCLE

New, active, lapsing, churned.

PERSONA

Students, professionals, families, flatmates.

OCCASION

Weekday lunch, late night, weekend treat, party.

[Lifecycle or behavior] + [Persona] + [Occasion]

Candidate segments

- Lapsing working professionals who used to order weekday lunch
- New users who ordered once and never returned
- Flatmates ordering weekday dinner
- Families ordering weekend dinner

Rules for a good segment

- Two to three lenses at most, or it gets too small
- Every lens must change what you would build
- Always include the occasion, it is where ideas come from

03 · SEGMENT CHOICE

Lapsing professionals at weekday lunch

Scored on size, room to order more, clarity of pain, and fit with the frequency goal (1 to 5).

SEGMENT	SIZE	GAP	PAIN	GOAL FIT	TOTAL
Lapsing professionals, weekday lunch	**4**	**5**	**4**	**5**	**18**
New users, one order only	5	4	3	4	16
Late night, binge occasion	3	3	3	3	12
Families, weekend dinner	3	2	2	2	9

Why this segment wins

- **Built in habit:** lunch happens five days a week, so the ceiling is high
- **Proven intent:** they ordered before, so winning back is cheaper than creating demand
- **Something changed:** and that change is findable
- **Direct goal fit:** every recovered lunch is one more order per user

Lapsing means they ordered four or more times a month earlier and now order once or twice. It targets the within segment drop, not all professionals.

04 · PAIN POINTS

Why they stopped ordering lunch

Mapped across the lunch journey. Alternatives like the canteen are not a pain themselves, they win because of the pains below.

DECIDING

Deciding daily is tiring and repetitive

Many options, but they all feel the same.

COST

Daily cost adds up

Fewer discounts, added fees, five days a week.

DELIVERY

Unreliable timing for a fixed break

Fifteen minutes late breaks a meeting slot.

EATING

Feels heavy for daily eating

Afternoon slump, not built for every day.

RECEIVING

Office access friction

Gate pickup, security, walking down.

CONTEXT

Hybrid work broke the habit

Fewer office days, fewer lunch occasions.

05 · PRIORITIZATION

Two pains tie at the top

Scored 1 to 5. Impact means how much it hurts the goal, not how solvable it is. For effort, 5 means easiest.

PAIN	REACH	IMPACT	EFFORT	TOTAL
Decision fatigue	**5**	**3**	**5**	**13**
Daily cost	**5**	**5**	**3**	**13**
Unreliable delivery time	4	5	1	10
Heavy or unhealthy food	3	3	4	10
Office access	3	3	2	8
Hybrid work	3	4	1	8

Decision fatigue

Fully within product control and fast to test. It slows the order more than it stops it.

Daily cost

Stops the order outright and explains the lapse. Only partly in Zomato's hands, since restaurants set menu prices.

Both are taken forward as two solution tracks: a fast experiment and a bigger bet.

Scores are hypotheses. Validate with browse to no order drop off and order timing by day of week.

06 · PROBLEM STATEMENTS

Two problems worth solving

Format: for [segment], [pain] causes [behavior], which hurts [goal].

PROBLEM 1 · DECISION FATIGUE

For lapsing working professionals in metros who used to order weekday lunch, deciding what to eat every day is tiring because the app shows many options that feel repetitive, so they default to the canteen, which needs no decision. This lowers orders per user.

Insight: the canteen wins on zero effort to decide, not on taste or price.

PROBLEM 2 · DAILY COST

For the same professionals, the rising daily cost of lunch, with fewer discounts and added fees, makes Zomato feel unaffordable as a daily habit, so they switch to canteens and nearby shops on most days. This lowers orders per user.

Constraint: no fixing it with discounts, that breaks the order value guardrail.

07 · SOLUTION SPACE

Ideas for each problem

FOR DECISION FATIGUE

IDEA	WHAT IT DOES
Quick Lunch	**One tap usual, swipe suggestions if not**
Lunch mode	Home switches to lunch only, 11:30 to 2:30
Plan the week	Pick five lunches on Monday, delivered daily
On this day	What you ate on a past date. Fun, but weak

FOR DAILY COST, WITHOUT DISCOUNTS

IDEA	HOW IT LOWERS COST
Lunch Pass	**Prepaid lunches, predictable demand, lower price**
Office batch delivery	One rider, many orders, lower fee
Everyday value menu	Simple meals at canteen like prices
Employer meal wallet	Company subsidises lunch as a benefit

Picked on impact, effort and speed to learn. Office batch delivery has high impact but is ops heavy, so it moves to a later phase.

08 · SOLUTION 1

Quick Lunch: make deciding as easy as the canteen

1 · WEEKDAYS, 11:30 TO 1:30

A card on home: your usual, price, and delivery time.

→

2 · TAP TO ORDER

Done in one tap.

→

3 · NOT TODAY?

Five suggestion cards, like a friend offering options. Swipe right to order, left for next.

→

4 · SKIP

Hides for the day. Turn it off any time in settings.

In the MVP

- Card on home only, no push notifications
- Suggestions from past orders and top rated lunch spots nearby
- Only restaurants delivering in under 30 minutes

Left for later

- Weekly planning
- Learning from swipes
- Push reminders

Who sees it first

10% of lapsing professionals in one metro, against a control group. Tests the core bet: does removing the decision bring them back?

08 · SOLUTION 2

Lunch Pass: lower the daily cost, build the habit

Prepaying for lunches lowers the price per meal and pulls users back daily. It moves cost and frequency together.

The offer

- A pass of 10 weekday lunches
- About 20% cheaper per meal than ordering normally
- Valid for 30 days

Why restaurants agree

- Guaranteed, predictable lunch volume
- Fills spare kitchen capacity at midday
- Fixed menu means simpler prep

In the MVP

- 15 to 20 partner restaurants in office zones of one metro
- Fixed lunch menu, weekdays only
- Offered to lapsing professionals only

Left for later: custom menus, more cities, office batch delivery, employer tie ups.

09 · METRICS

How we know it worked

North star for both: weekday lunch orders per user per month, test group versus control. Measured against control so moved orders are not mistaken for new ones.

QUICK LUNCH

TYPE	METRIC
Input	Card tap rate: taps ÷ card views
Input	One tap order rate
Input	Swipe to order rate
Input	Time from card view to order
Guardrail	Share of orders from new restaurants
Guardrail	Turn off rate, average order value

LUNCH PASS

TYPE	METRIC
Input	Pass purchase rate: buys ÷ views
Input	Redemption: lunches used ÷ bought
Input	Repurchase rate: bought a second pass
Guardrail	Contribution margin per order
Guardrail	Restaurant partner satisfaction

10 · RISKS AND TRADEOFFS

What could go wrong

QUICK LUNCH

RISK	MITIGATION
The usual gets boring, the very pain being solved	One new pick in every five cards
Thin history for light users	Fall back to top rated spots nearby
Orders concentrate on top restaurants	Rotate quality restaurants, cap exposure
Orders only move from browsing to the card	Judge success against control

Tradeoffs: speed versus discovery, personal versus fair.

LUNCH PASS

RISK	MITIGATION
Cheaper meals lose money	Lower margin traded for guaranteed volume
Unused passes feel like a loss	Usage reminders, pause or extend
Heavy users pay less for orders they would make anyway	Offer to lapsing users only
Quality drops to protect margin	Fixed standards, pass specific ratings

Tradeoffs: price versus margin, commitment versus flexibility.

11 · ROLLOUT

Fast experiment first, bigger bet second

PHASE 1 · WEEKS 1 TO 4

Test Quick Lunch

10% of lapsing professionals in one metro, with a control group.

Continue if: lunch orders per user rise versus control and turn off rate stays under 5%.

Stop if: no lift after four weeks, or turn off rate passes 10%.

PHASE 2 · WEEKS 5 TO 12

Pilot Lunch Pass, scale Quick Lunch

Pass in two office zones with 15 to 20 restaurants. Quick Lunch to half the segment, learning from swipes.

Continue if: redemption above 70%, repurchase above 30%, margin positive.

PHASE 3 · MONTHS 4 TO 6

Combine and expand

Pass lunches show up inside Quick Lunch. Expand to top metros. Add office batch delivery and employer wallets.

Target: orders per user from 3.2 to 3.8.

	QUICK LUNCH	LUNCH PASS
Effort	Low, interface on existing data	Medium, partners and pricing
Time to learn	2 to 4 weeks	6 to 8 weeks
Upside	Moderate	High

TAKEAWAYS

What this case taught

1 Diagnose before solving

A falling average can mean growth or decline. Split the metric and check segments first.

2 Pick, do not list

Scoring makes the tradeoff visible. Impact and solvability are scored separately.

3 Find what the alternative wins on

The canteen beats the app on effort to decide and on cost, not on food.

4 Measure against control

High adoption can hide zero new orders. Only a control group shows real lift.

Run the cheap experiment first, learn what brings people back, then place the bigger bet.